



UGANDA

Capital city: Kampala
Area: 91,135 sq miles (236,040 sq km)
Population: 25,800,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Traditional beliefs 84%, Muslim 8%, other 8%
Government: Non-party government
Currency: New Uganda Shilling
Adult literacy rate: 69%
Life expectancy: 43 years
People per doctor: 20,000
Televisions: 27 per 1,000 people

UGANDA

BEFORE INDEPENDENCE IN 1962, Uganda was a prosperous country – Winston Churchill called it the “Pearl of Africa.” But by 1986, the country lay shattered and bankrupt. From 1971–79, President Idi Amin ruled Uganda as a dictator. Thousands of people were persecuted or murdered. Europeans and Asians were expelled and their property seized. International aid was cut off when other countries realized how corrupt Amin’s government was. In 1979, Amin was deposed, but the disruption continued until 1986, when President Yoweri Museveni came to power. His government restored peace and has begun to rebuild the economy.



FISHING IN LAKE VICTORIA
Vast, shallow Lake Victoria is shared by Uganda, Tanzania, and Kenya. Huge Nile perch fish were introduced to the lake 30 years ago to increase fish production and provide sport fishing for tourists. Since then the perch have spread to every corner of Lake Victoria and have devoured most of its original species.

The cassava plant grows up to 3 ft (90 cm) tall. It is grown for its roots, which can be eaten as a vegetable or ground to make flour.



Kampala is said to be built on seven hills. The city center lies on just one of them – Nakasero Hill.



FARMING

Fertile, volcanic soil and high levels of rainfall make more than four-fifths of Uganda’s land suitable for farming. Large plantations produce the coffee, cotton, and tea that make up 90 percent of the country’s exports.

Although 90 percent of Ugandans work on farms, most are involved in small-scale farming, growing crops such as corn, millet, cassava, and sweet potatoes for their own use or to sell in local markets.



Sweet potato (left) and cassava (right) are common vegetables in this region.

KAMPALA

People in Uganda’s capital, Kampala, rarely go out without an umbrella, since most days see a heavy downpour in the afternoon. Kampala has an average of 242 days a year with violent thunderstorms. By evening, the rain has stopped and the air is cool. Kampala suffered much destruction during and immediately after Amin’s period in power, but is now being restored with the help of foreign investment.



AIDS AWARENESS

Uganda has one of the highest numbers of HIV and AIDS sufferers in the world. HIV (which can lead to AIDS) is a mainly sexually transmitted disease and as yet there is no known cure for it. Doctors are trying to teach people how to avoid contracting the disease. Special campaigns aimed at educating children, such as this UNICEF poster, have dramatically reduced the rate of infection.



WILDLIFE

In Ruwenzori National Park, tourists can take a boat trip down the Kazinga Channel to see thousands of hippos and pelicans. Much of Uganda’s wildlife was wiped out during the years of conflict, and today there are not many places in Africa where you are likely to see so many hippos.

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